



reports. CCTV footage from June 13 of a group wearing Rapid Action Force (RAF) uniforms and wielding shields and weapons even as they vandalised cars in Imphal West further proved that the lines between protectors and perpetrators had blurred. Policing has been almost absent in the state in the past couple of months. Victims from both sides allege that the police remained mute spectators and, at times, even egged on the rioters.

From 1,487 FIRs on May 2, the number reached 11,730 by July 10, highlighting the extent of the ethnic violence. Though only one case has been registered under Section 376 (pertaining to rape), multiple accounts of sexual crimes are gradually surfacing. And Biren seems to have done little to ease the suspicion between the two warring groups. If 10 Kuki MLAs submitted a memorandum to the Union home minister Amit Shah, alleging that all Kuki police officers, from the DG to the constables, were stripped of all power, disarmed and rendered inactive long before May 3, Biren's response was to replace the Kuki DGP P. Doungel with Tripura-cadre IPS officer Rajiv Singh. Survivors and kin of victims allege the police have been comatose and the state government and CM complicit.

BLUNDER 2: AN INEPT CM

Nongthombam Biren Singh, a Meitei who returned as chief minister for a second term in 2022, has had a chequered political career. He played good football in his youth, even joining the Border Security Force to further his sporting career before returning to journalism and politics. He joined the Congress in 2003, which was in power in Manipur then, and held ministerial posts. However, he and a few other Congress MLAs revolted in 2016 and joined the BJP. Though the saffron party won only 21 of the state's 60 seats on its own in the 2017 state polls, it managed to cobble together a majority and Biren became the first BJP politician to head the state government since its inception.

THE MANIPUR CM WAS PERCEIVED AS ANTI-KUKI TO BEGIN WITH, HIS BIASED STATEMENTS INDIRECTLY ASSOCIATING KUKIS WITH POPPY CULTIVATION ALIENATED THEM EVEN FURTHER

Soon after assuming charge, Biren launched a war on drug trafficking in Manipur, particularly the cultivation of poppy. State data show that between 2017 and 2022, the acreage under poppy grew almost threefold, from 1,853 acres to 6,743 acres. With 10 per cent of its population addicted, Manipur is among the five states that have the highest incidence of opioid (poppy-derived drugs) use in India. As the government went about destroying poppy fields, a majority of them in Kuki-inhabited areas, the community got suspicious of the CM's intent as he was perceived as anti-Kuki from the very start. It did not help that the CM made several statements indirectly holding Kukis solely accountable for poppy cultivation, even though some Meiteis and Nagas also grow poppy. Meitei civil society groups added further fuel. The Coordinating Committee on Manipur Integrity (COCOMI), an umbrella organisation of Meiteis, has labelled Kuki militant groups "narco-terrorists".

A second drive by the Biren government, this time against illegal encroachment in forest areas, lit a further spark in the rivalry. The Kukis saw it as one more attack on them, claiming that legitimate residents had been evicted. A few Kuki organisations even allege that the government's eviction drive is a